2026 Professional Development Conference - Planning Brief

Northbridge Engineering Group, Inc. — 15 December 2025

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Northbridge Engineering Group, Inc. — Learning & Development

Issued 15 December 2025 by Catherine Wallace, Program Coordinator, Learning & Development, for Brenda Stewart, Director of Learning & Development. This brief sets out the plan for the 2026 firm conference and the material the budget application to the review committee is built on.

1.1 1 Purpose and background

The Professional Development Conference is the firm's annual off-site program for engineering and shared-services staff. It began in 2014 as a one-day Denver seminar and has grown into a three-day program drawing attendees from all thirteen regional offices. The conference combines technical short courses, leadership sessions and an early career program, and since 2022 it has carried a pre-conference intensive for a small enrolled group.

Last year's program in Fort Collins hosted 24 attendees; feedback asked for a venue that would let the off-site groups work together for the full week rather than travel in daily. This year the program moves to a mountain venue with the full week available, including the weekend intensive.

The department submits a budget application to the review committee each January. This brief is the planning record behind that application: the event, its venue and lodging arrangements, the guest and companion program, the fee schedule, and the policy provisions that govern conference travel.

1.2 2 Event overview

The 2026 conference is hosted in **Steamboat Springs, Colorado** (Routt County), a town of about 13,000 in the Yampa valley, roughly three hours' drive northwest of Denver. Attendees fly into Hayden (HDN) or Denver International and reach the town by shuttle or rental car.

The program runs from **Tuesday 2 June 2026 to Friday 5 June 2026**. A **pre-conference intensive** runs on the weekend before the program, **Saturday 30 and Sunday 31 May 2026**; enrollment in the intensive is limited to twelve and is set by nomination.

Four session tracks make up the program:

Table 1

Track	Audience	Sessions
Leadership	Project managers and senior staff	Roundtables, governance, client partnerships
Technical	Engineering staff across disciplines	Short courses in water resources, structures, environmental, geotechnical
Early career	Staff in their first three years	Fundamentals clinics, mentoring, licensing preparation
Pre-conference intensive	Enrolled nominees (weekend before)	Two-day modelling workshop, Saturday and Sunday

Expected attendance is 25 to 30 staff, based on 28 nominations received in the autumn window.

1.3 3 Venue and lodging

The host venue is the **Cascade Ridge Hotel** on the edge of the town, which holds the plenary room, the four break-out rooms and the dinner hall under one roof.

The firm holds a contracted **conference-block room rate of $219 per night plus tax** at the host hotel, for single or double occupancy. The block covers the nights of **1 to 5 June 2026**, and a limited number of rooms are held for the pre-conference intensive weekend for early-arriving attendees. Block reservations are made through the Learning & Development coordinator by the block cutoff date of **1 May 2026**; after that date unclaimed rooms return to the hotel's general inventory.

Attendees who prefer other lodging may arrange it themselves and submit it through the ordinary expense process; the town has condominium rentals, lodges and smaller inns beyond walking distance of the venue. Attendees arranging their own lodging are responsible for their own bookings and cancellations.

The hotel offers the firm a complimentary hospitality suite on the Wednesday evening and free parking for attendees; neither carries a charge to the program.

1.4 4 Program at a glance

Table 2

Day	Morning	Afternoon	Evening
Monday 1 June	Arrivals and registration desk	Regional office caucuses	Welcome reception
Tuesday 2 June	Opening plenary	Technical short courses, round one	Free evening
Wednesday 3 June	Leadership track; technical clinics	Field session on the Yampa restoration project	Conference dinner (guest tickets on the fee schedule)
Thursday 4 June	Technical short courses, round two	Early career clinics	Poster session and reception
Friday 5 June	Project governance panel	Closing plenary and awards	Departures

The pre-conference intensive runs all day Saturday 30 and Sunday 31 May, with a group dinner on the Saturday evening for enrolled attendees.

1.5 5 Guest and companion program

The conference welcomes guests and companions. The program offers three guest items:

- **Guest registration**, which covers a guest badge, entry to the plenary and exhibit hall, and the Wednesday reception.
- **Guest dinner**, the conference dinner on Wednesday 3 June, held in the hotel's dinner hall with a fixed menu.
- **Companion lodging add-on**, arranged through the coordinator, which adds a companion to the attendee's room booking for the conference nights.

Guests and companions are welcome at the evening receptions, and the town's summer activities schedule is circulated with the joining instructions. Guest tickets for the dinner and the companion arrangements are ordered at the time the nominee confirms attendance; the coordinator records them on the nomination form.

Attendees' own registration is part of the conference organization and is met from the departmental program budget; it is not charged to the attendee or to office travel budgets.

1.6 6 Fees and fee schedule

The fee schedule agreed with the venue and the program suppliers:

Table 3

Item	Fee
Early registration (until 15 January 2026)	$625 per attendee
Standard registration (16 January to 30 April 2026)	$725 per attendee
Late registration (from 1 May 2026)	$825 per attendee
Guest registration	$195 per guest
Guest dinner	$120 per guest
Companion lodging add-on	$110 per night

Registration fees are invoiced to the department by the conference organizer after the filing of the budget application.

1.7 7 Governing policy provisions

Conference travel is governed by section 7 of the firm's Travel & Expense Policy Manual (Conference Travel), in force from 1 October 2025. The provisions relevant to this program are extracted here:

- Conference travel at company expense requires the traveler's manager's written approval, on file at the time the budget application is submitted.
- An employee who has attended an externally hosted conference of two or more days within the twelve months preceding the first day of the event is not eligible to attend at company expense, and an employee still serving the probationary period may attend only with a director-level exception recorded in the approval file.
- Lodging is reimbursed only up to the applicable per diem rate, and company-supported conference arrangements are governed by the federal conference planning framework adopted by this policy (41 CFR part 301-74).

The policy incorporates the per diem provisions of the Federal Travel Regulation (41 CFR part 301-11). Among the quoted provisions:

- "Your TDY location determines your maximum per diem reimbursement rate." (§ 301-11.7)
- "When travel is more than 12 hours and overnight lodging is required you are reimbursed your actual lodging cost not to exceed the maximum lodging rate for the TDY location or stopover point." (§ 301-11.100)
- "For travel of 24 hours or more, your M&IE allowance is 75 percent of the applicable M&IE rate on the day of departure, 100 percent of the applicable M&IE rate on full days of travel, and 75 percent of the applicable M&IE rate on the last day of travel." (§ 301-11.101)

The applicable per diem tables are those published for the fiscal year of travel; the rates in force for this program are the FY2026 tables, effective 1 October 2025. The coordinator keeps the current table for the conference state with the program file.

1.8 8 Nominations and approvals

Nominations opened on **17 November 2025** and closed on **19 December 2025**. Managers nominated staff on the conference nomination form, choosing a session track and recording the nominee's travel and lodging request; the form collects the nominee's contact email, home office, planned arrival and departure, and any guest or companion items.

Each nomination carries the manager's approval capture as the coordinator recorded it at the close of the window, together with the approval date and any approval notes. Where an approval action happened outside the form, the coordinator attached the record to the nomination.

The nomination export, the employee roster and the staff travel log accompany this brief as the program file. Nominations are reconciled against the roster before any determination is drafted.

1.9 9 Budget application and review committee

The travel and lodging application is filed with the **budget review committee**, chaired by Peter Carlson. The filing deadline is **Friday 6 February 2026**; the committee meets the following week.

The committee applies a **travel and lodging cap of $75,000** to this year's application. Figures in the application are checked by Finance against the published per diem tables; last year's application cleared

committee on the strength of its per diem footing.

The application covers travel and lodging for proposed attendees, itemized by traveler.

1.10 10 Key dates and contacts

Table 4

Date	Milestone
17 November 2025	Nominations open
19 December 2025	Nominations close
15 January 2026	Early registration ends
1 May 2026	Hotel block cutoff
6 February 2026	Budget application due to the review committee
30–31 May 2026	Pre-conference intensive
2–5 June 2026	Conference program

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